

Rocks, soil, and fossils

The rocks that make up Earth's hard outer shell are often covered by soil, sand, ice, or water. Some contain fossils, which tell us about life on Earth long ago.

Rocks

Rocks are made of tiny crystals of natural substances called **minerals**. The main types of rock are called sedimentary, igneous, and metamorphic.

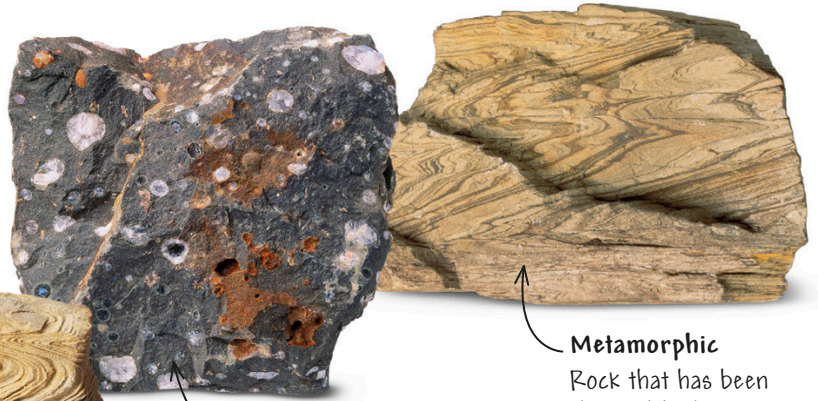
Sedimentary

This rock is made from sand, mud, or minerals from the shells and skeletons of sea creatures.



Igneous

This rock is formed when magma (hot, molten rock) cools and hardens.



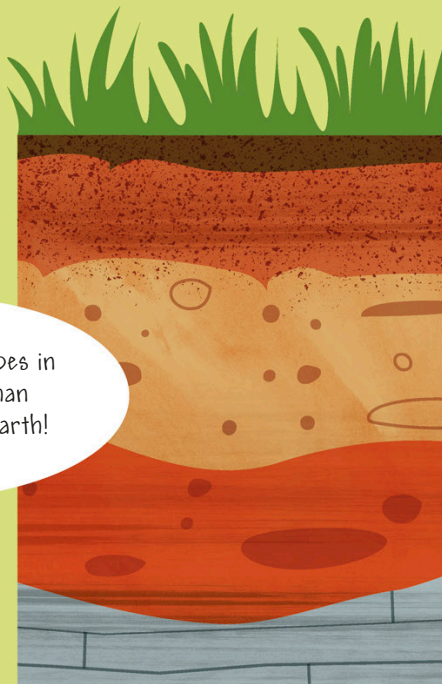
Metamorphic

Rock that has been changed by heat and high pressure underground is called metamorphic.

Soil

Soil is the loose material that covers much of the land, and it's where plants grow. It's made of rotten material mixed with minerals and bits of broken rock.

There are more microbes in a teaspoon of soil than there are people on Earth!



Humus is the rotting remains of dead plants and animals.

Topsoil is a mixture of minerals and humus. Many plant roots grow here.

Subsoil is rich in minerals. It has less humus than topsoil.

This layer is mostly made of large rock pieces. Plant roots don't reach this far.

Under the soil layers is solid rock called **bedrock**.